

A2 (WITH B1 STRETCH) · IELTS-STYLE READING INPUT

Modifiers: Gerunds & Infinitives

Gerunds, Gerund Phrases, Infinitives & Infinitive Phrases

 -ing form · gerund

 to + verb · infinitive

Reading text: "Why People Never Stop Learning"

01

WARM-UP

Talk About Hobbies



Swimming



Reading



Cooking



Playing the Guitar



Travelling



Painting

What is this person doing? Which do you enjoy? Which would you like to try one day?

Why People Never Stop Learning

Learning new things *is* one of the best ways to stay happy and healthy. Doctors say that keeping your brain active can help people live longer. This is why many older people enjoy taking classes, joining clubs, or trying a new hobby.

Take Mrs Ahmed, a 68-year-old grandmother from Dhaka. Two years ago, she decided to learn how to paint. At first, she found holding a paintbrush difficult, and her hands would shake. However, she kept practising every day. Now, painting is her favourite way to relax, and she loves showing her pictures to her grandchildren.

Learning a language later in life *is* also becoming popular. Mr Karim, a retired teacher, wanted to visit his son in Canada, so he began learning French. "To speak with my son's family was my biggest dream," he says.

Why People Never Stop Learning

His son wanted him **to stay** for a whole year, so Mr Karim asked his teacher **to help** him practise every day. He finds **memorising** new words hard, but he refuses **to give up**. Every morning, he spends thirty minutes **reading** French news online before **going to work** in his garden.

Experts agree that **trying** new activities is important for our minds. **Sitting** alone at home and **doing** nothing can make people feel lonely, but **joining** a class gives them a reason **to get up** in the morning and meet new people. It also helps them feel proud of themselves.

So, next time you think it's too late **to start** something new, remember Mrs Ahmed and Mr Karim. It is never too late **to learn** a new skill, meet new friends, or discover a hidden talent. All you need **to do** is take the first step and keep **going**.

Noticing Worksheet

Read the text again. Highlight every -ing word in YELLOW. Highlight every to + verb phrase in BLUE. Then answer the questions below in your group.

COLOUR KEY



Yellow highlight

an -ing word acting like a noun (a gerund)



Blue / cyan highlight

to + base verb (an infinitive)

Work through the same reading text from the previous slide, then move on to the guided questions.

Guided Noticing Questions (1–5)

- Look at “Learning new things is one of the best ways...” What word comes right after “Learning new things”? What kind of word usually goes in that position — a noun, a verb, or an adjective?
- Find another -ing phrase that starts a sentence. What job is it doing?
- Look at “she loves showing her pictures.” Could you replace “showing her pictures” with a simple noun like “photos”? What does that tell you about “showing” here?
- Compare “she kept practising every day” with “trying new activities is important.” Is the -ing word doing the same job in both sentences?
- Find three verbs that are followed directly by “to + verb” (e.g. decided to learn). List them.

Guided Noticing Questions (6–9)

- Find a sentence where “to + verb” comes right after an adjective (e.g. too late to start). Can you find a second one?
- Find: “His son wanted him to stay for a whole year.” Who actually does the “staying” — the son, or Mr Karim? What comes between “wanted” and “to stay”?
- Find: “helps them feel proud of themselves.” Compare this with “wanted him to stay.” What word is missing after “helps them”?
- Find one -ing word that comes directly after a small word like “before” or “without.” What kind of word usually follows “before / without / after” in English?

Gerund or Participle?

Label the -ing word in each sentence: V (part of the verb), Adj (describing a noun), or N (a noun / gerund).

1. Mrs Ahmed is **learning** to paint every week. (____)
2. **Learning** new things keeps her happy. (____)
3. I saw a **smiling** teacher **helping** her students. (____ / ____)
4. **Helping** new students is very **rewarding**. (____)

Sort Your Examples

Function	Example from the text
Gerund as subject	Learning new things is...
Gerund as direct object (after a verb)	she loves showing her pictures
Gerund after a preposition	before going to work
Infinitive as subject	To speak with my son's family was...
Infinitive as direct object (after a verb)	decided to learn / refuses to give up
Infinitive after an adjective	too late to start
Infinitive with its own subject	wanted him to stay
Infinitive with 'to' dropped	helps them (to) feel proud

Build the Rule

GUIDING QUESTIONS

- Where do gerunds usually appear in a sentence? Name two positions.
- List the verbs from the text that are followed directly by an -ing form (not 'to').
- List the verbs from the text that are followed directly by 'to + verb'.
- What pattern do you see after adjectives like important, difficult, too late?
- In “wanted him to stay” and “asked his teacher to help,” what pattern do you notice?
- In “helps them feel proud,” is 'to' used? Can you find another verb that behaves the same way?

WRITE YOUR RULE

In your group, write ONE rule for gerunds and ONE rule for infinitives — in your own words.

There's no single “perfect” wording. Aim for a rule that fits every example you found.

Our rule for GERUNDS:

Our rule for INFINITIVES:

Gerunds (verb + -ing)

A gerund behaves like a noun.

It can be the **subject** of a sentence, the **object of a verb**, the **object of a preposition**, a **predicate nominative** after 'be' (Her passion is painting), or an **appositive**

(Her hobby, painting, keeps her calm).

Certain verbs are always followed by a gerund, never by 'to + verb':

enjoy

love

keep

finish

avoid

mind

suggest

spend time + -ing

Infinitives (to + base verb)

An infinitive can act as a noun, an adjective, or an adverb.

Noun (subject / object) — decided to learn, refuses to give up

Adjective — after nouns like reason, or adjectives like important / difficult / too late

Adverb (purpose) — she practises to improve

Person + infinitive — want / ask / tell / would like + person + to + verb (e.g. want him to stay)

Bare infinitive — after make, let, help (and some perception verbs), 'to' is dropped (helped him practise / made her laugh)

Followed directly by to + verb: want · decide · hope · refuse · need · plan · ask · tell

Exercise 1 — Gap-Fill

Put the verb in brackets into the gerund (-ing) or the infinitive (to + verb) form.

1. She enjoys ____ (read) books before bed.
2. I decided ____ (learn) a new language this year.
3. ____ (exercise) every day is good for your health.
4. He refuses ____ (give) up on his dream.
5. They finished ____ (write) their reports at 5 p.m.
6. It's important ____ (practise) speaking every day.
7. My teacher wanted me ____ (finish) the homework by Monday.
8. We spent an hour ____ (talk) about our plans.
9. My mother helped me ____ (cook) dinner.
10. It is never too late ____ (start) something new.

Exercise 2 — Sentence Transformation

Combine each pair into ONE sentence, using a gerund or an infinitive.

1. Mrs Ahmed paints. She enjoys it. → _____

2. Mr Karim wants something. He wants to speak French. → _____

3. It's difficult. You must learn a new skill after 60. → _____

4. She practises every day. She hopes to improve. → _____

5. His teacher helped him. He practised his pronunciation. → _____

Exercise 3 — Error Correction

Each sentence has ONE mistake with a gerund or infinitive. Find and correct it.

1. *She enjoys to read books.*
2. *I decided learning French.*
3. *To learning new things are exciting.*
4. *He wanted that I help him.*
5. *It's too late learn a new skill.*

Answer Key: Exercises 1–3

EXERCISE 1

1. reading
2. to learn
3. Exercising
4. to give
5. writing
6. to practise
7. to finish
8. talking
9. cook (to cook also OK)
10. to start

EXERCISE 2

1. Mrs Ahmed enjoys painting.
2. Mr Karim wants to speak French.
3. It's difficult to learn a new skill after 60.
4. She practises every day to improve.
5. His teacher helped him practise his pronunciation.

EXERCISE 3

1. ...enjoys reading books.
2. ...decided to learn French.
3. Learning new things is exciting.
4. ...wanted me to help him.
5. ...too late to learn a new skill.

Life Goals & Habits Interview

DISCUSSION CARDS

- What do you enjoy doing in your free time?
- What have you decided to try this year?
- What is something you find difficult to do?
- What do you hope to achieve in the next five years?
- Is it ever too late to learn something new? Why, or why not?
- What does your family want you to do in the future?

SENTENCE STARTERS

I enjoy _____-ing...

I want to...

It's important to...

My goal is to...

My partner enjoys... and hopes to...

Writing Task

“Describe a skill you would like to learn, and explain why.”

80–100 words

Individual

3 gerunds

3 infinitives

Exit Ticket

Type ONE sentence with a gerund and ONE sentence with an infinitive — about YOU.

GERUND

INFINITIVE

Describe a New Skill You'd Like to Learn

Write a paragraph of 100–120 words, IELTS Writing-style, on the topic: “Describe a new skill you would like to learn and explain why.”

- Use at least FOUR gerunds and FOUR infinitives — underline each one.
- Stretch goal (optional): include one sentence with an infinitive that has its own subject (e.g. “I want my sister to teach me...”).
- Bring your paragraph to the next class, or submit it via the class shared folder before the next session.

SELF-CHECK LIST

- ✓ Did I use enjoy / love / keep / avoid / finish + -ing, not 'to'?
- ✓ Did I use decide / want / hope / refuse / need + to + verb?
- ✓ Did I add 'to' after adjectives like important, difficult, exciting?
- ✓ If I wrote 'want/ask/tell someone to do something,' did I avoid using 'that'?
- ✓ Does my gerund subject take a singular verb (e.g. Learning... is..., not are)?